Analysing Social Care Spending Across the European Union: The Case of Ireland

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1 Introduction

Underpaid and undervalued care work, rooted in systemic inequalities, has historically placed disproportionate burdens on women (Gould, Sawo and Banerjee, 2021). This gendered imbalance is especially reflected in social care, the relational and often intimate work that supports individuals daily functioning and wellbeing. In recent years, this sector has undergone significant shifts (Dowling, 2021; Simpson et al., 2022). European Union (EU) states exemplify vastly differing care regimes, defined by the roles of state, family, and market actors in providing care (Daly and Lewis, 2000; Van Damme, Spijker and Pavlopoulos, 2025). Broadly, these regimes can be categorised into public-centred, family-centred, and hybrid models.

Ireland represents a hybrid regime blending public and private care provision (Walsh and Connolly, 2024). Romania, a family-centered regime, invests little beyond healthcare, leaving social care primarily to families and private spending (Petre et al., 2023; OECD, 2025). Finland exemplifies a public-centered regime, with the state funding a comprehensive range of social services (Finland Ministry of Social Affairs and Health). Using these three countries as examples, this report examines Eurostat data on social expenditures across EU countries from 2000 to 2023 to answer the following question:

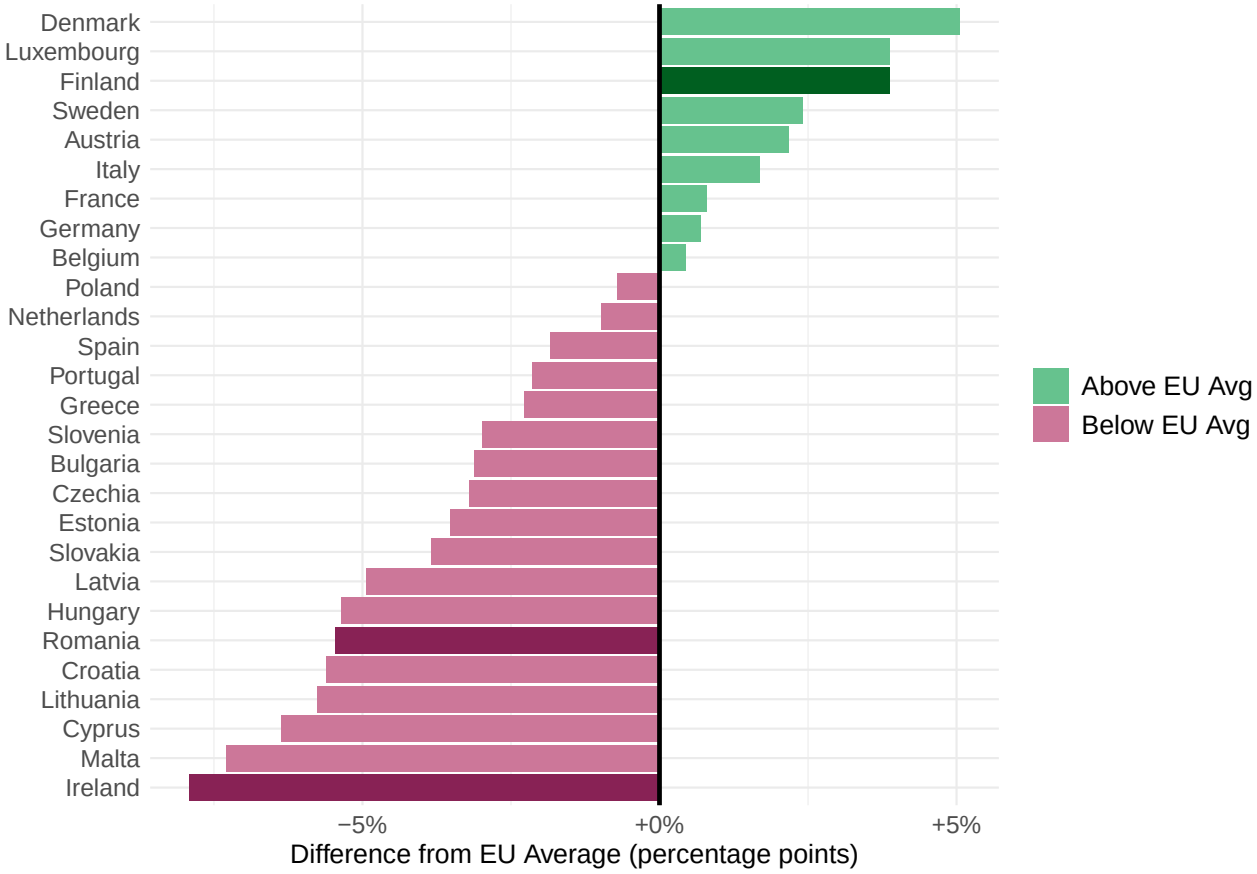
How does Ireland's spending on social care programs differ from other European Union countries?

In addition to Eurostat data on social expenditures, this report also utilizes Eurobank data on domestic demand for EU countries as a less biased indicator of overall state production (O'Donoghue, 2024). Eurostat data on frequency of family contact is also analysed to explore how social care spending relates to family structures among EU countries.

2 Social Care Spending Across the EU

To observe trends in EU countries' spending on social care relative to domestic demand in 2023, Figure 1 depicts countries' divergence from the EU average of this proportion. The EU average is calculated from total EU social care spending over total EU domestic demand, meaning larger economies influence the value more than smaller ones.

Figure 1: Social Care Spending as % of Domestic Demand (2023)
Deviation from EU Average (15.8%)

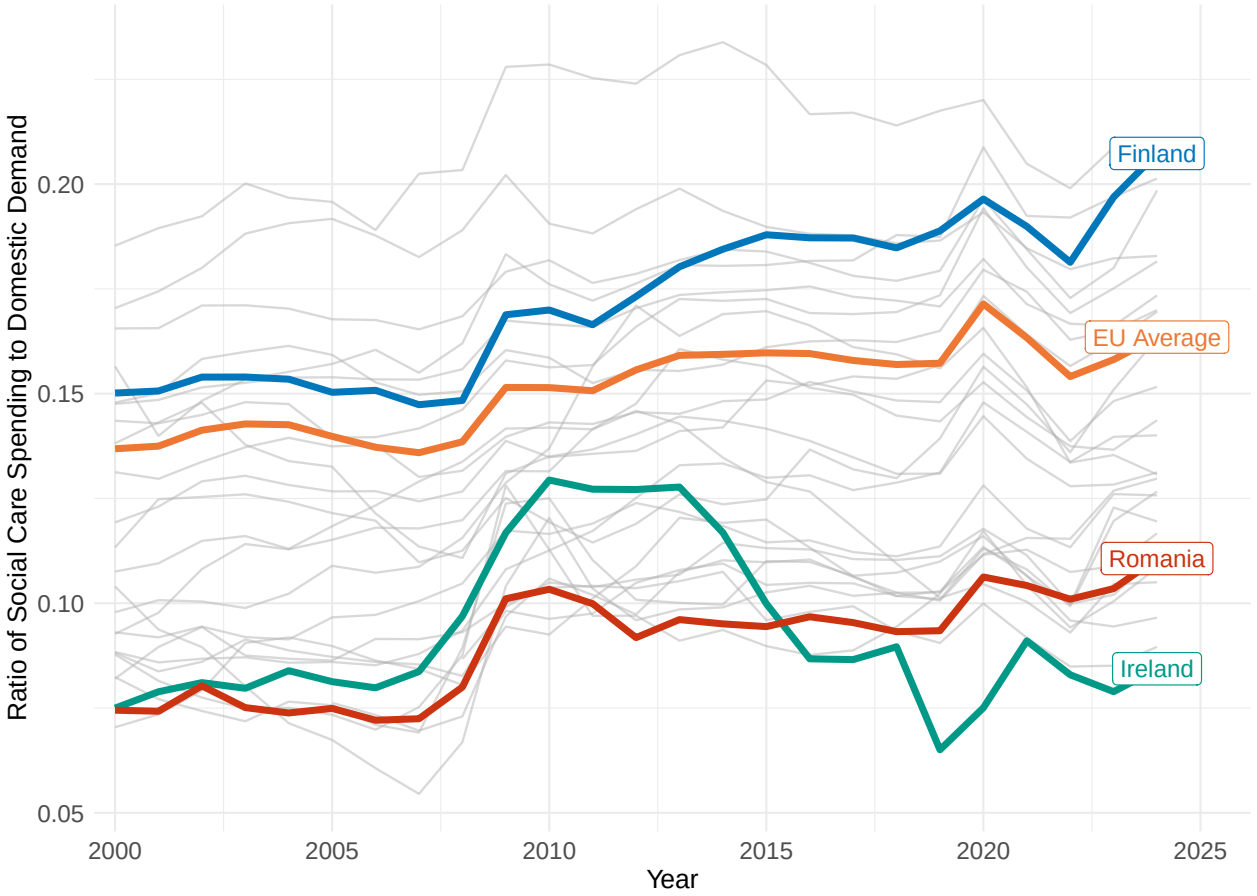


The EU average share of social care spending relative to domestic demand is 15.8%, with most of the largest EU economies falling above this level. Ireland deviates the most, allocating over 7% less than the EU average, while Romania spends roughly 5% less. By contrast, Finland spends about 3% more. Across Europe, spending patterns generally reflect care regime types. Public-centered care regimes, such as Nordic countries, generally spend the most on social care. Hybrid regimes cluster near the EU average, while family-centered models tend to fall well below it. Notably, Ireland, a hybrid model, spends the least on social care among all EU countries, contrary to expectations.

2.1 Development over time

As demographic and political shifts reshape expectations for social care, spending is expected to fluctuate over time. Figure 2 shows the ratio of social care spending to domestic demand from 2000 to 2023, highlighting the reference countries and the EU average, with all other EU countries shown in the background for reference.

Figure 2: Social Care Spending as a Proportion of Domestic Demand Over Time

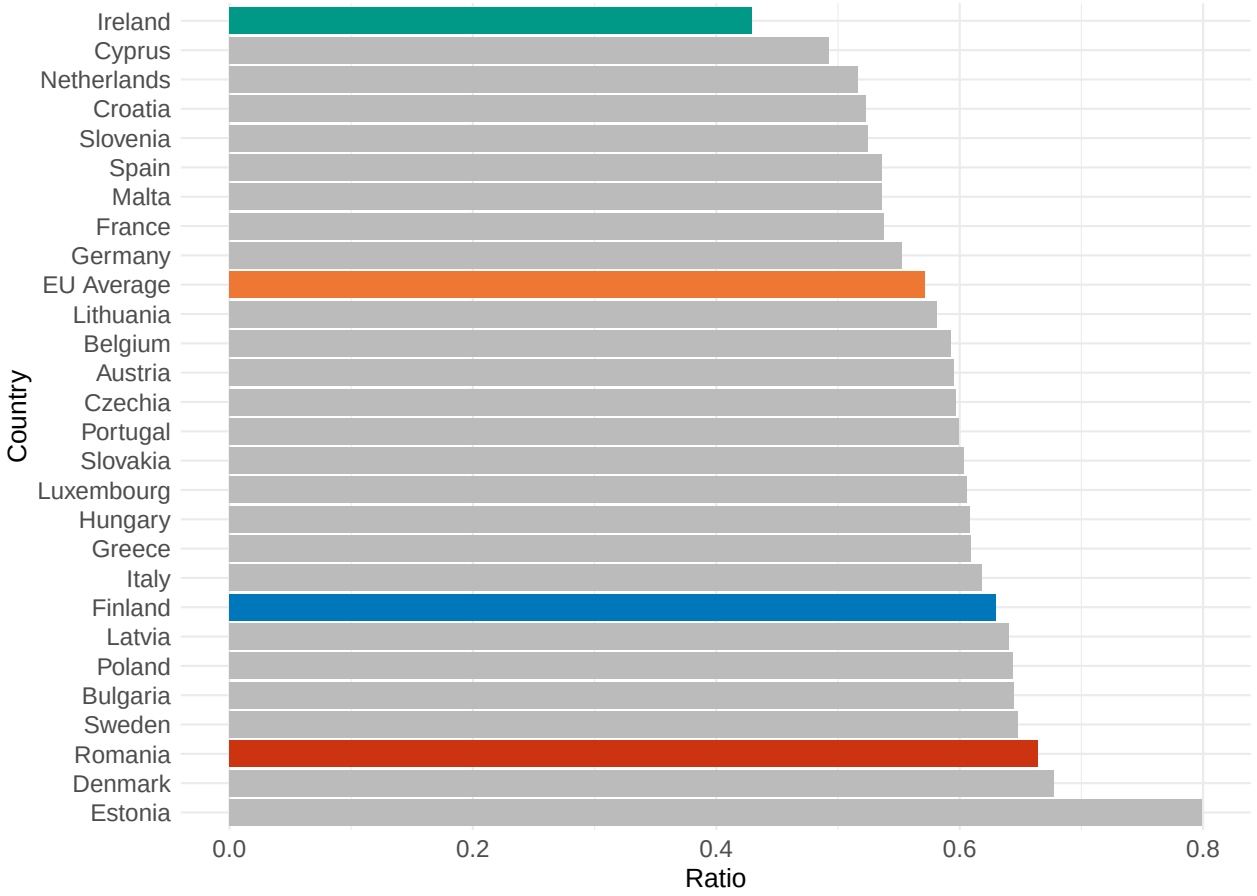


While social care spending has steadily increased from 2000 to 2023, there are several interesting trends within this time period. Ireland, Romania, Finland, and the EU average experienced a decline in social care spending after the 2009 Eurozone crisis and global economic recession (BBC, 2012). All the observed countries, as well as the EU average, show a significant uptick in spending around 2020 at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic (OECD, 2023). Interestingly, Ireland's COVID-19 related spending continued to increase until around 2022, longer than the other countries, which had already begun reducing their spending. Social care spending, like other spending areas, shifts in reaction to both external factors and changing demographics over time.

2.2 Social Care as a Proportion of Total Social Spending

Figure 3 depicts social care spending (defined here as the combined spending on Old Age, Family and Children, and Disability) as a proportion of total social spending for all EU countries in 2023.

Figure 3: Social Care Spending As Proportion of Total Social Spending (2023)

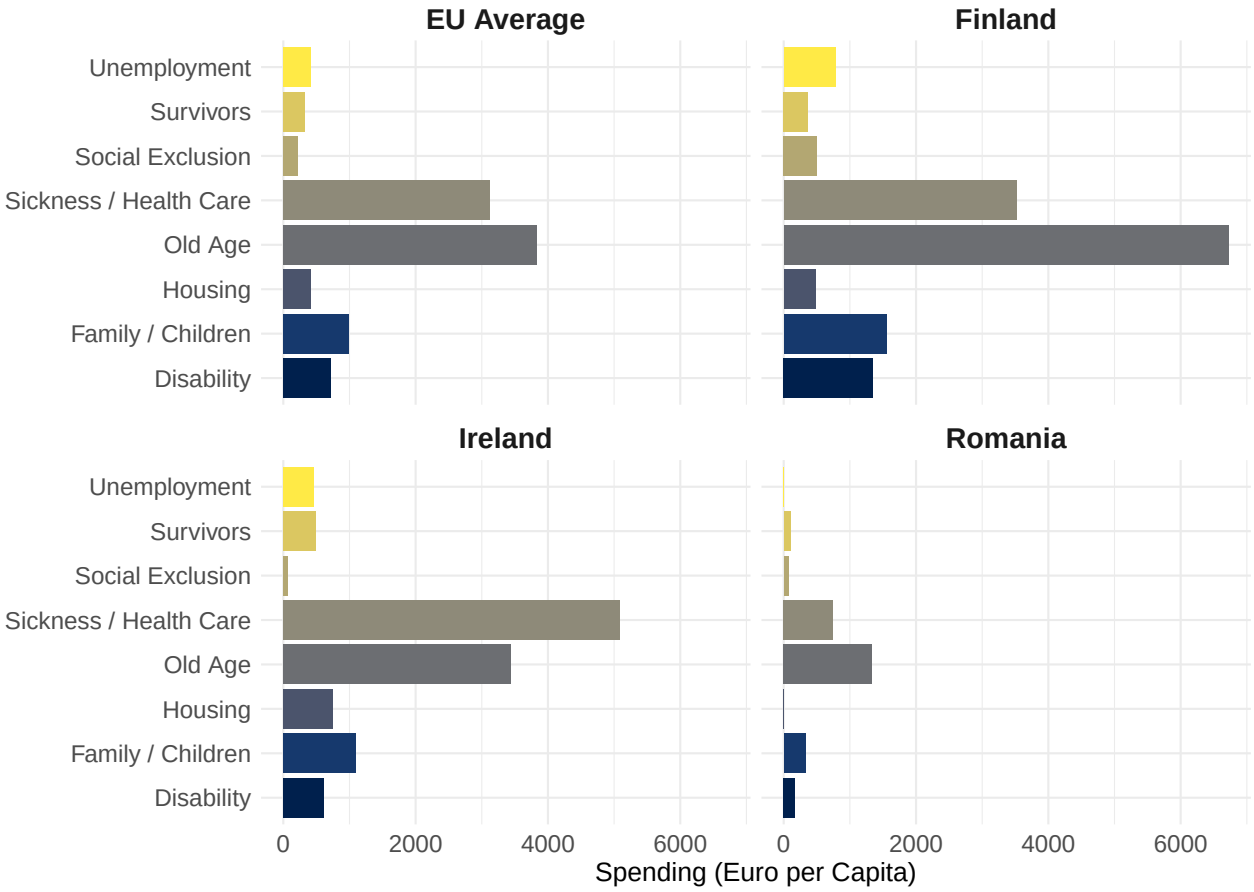


The graph reveals important variations across EU countries. Estonia allocates the highest share (approximately 80%) of total social spending to social care, likely because areas like housing, unemployment, and social exclusion take up a small share of spending (Eurostat, 2025). This combined with its aging population (Mass & Merilen, 2019). Nordic countries including Denmark and Sweden also spend large shares of total social spending on social care, consistent with their publicly-funded care systems. Ireland, by contrast, has one of the lowest shares, suggesting a greater focus on areas like healthcare. Romania ranks relatively high despite its family-centred model, likely because low overall social spending makes even modest social care spending a large proportion. Finland falls in the upper-middle range (around 65%), aligning with its public-centred regime. These contrasts show the need to take a closer look at how social spending is distributed across welfare categories, as illustrated in figure 4.

3 Breakdown of Social Care Spending

Figure 4 provides a per-capita breakdown of social spending across eight welfare areas for Ireland, Finland, Romania, and the EU average in 2023. It illustrates how different care regime types allocate resources.

Figure 4: Social Spending by Category (2023)

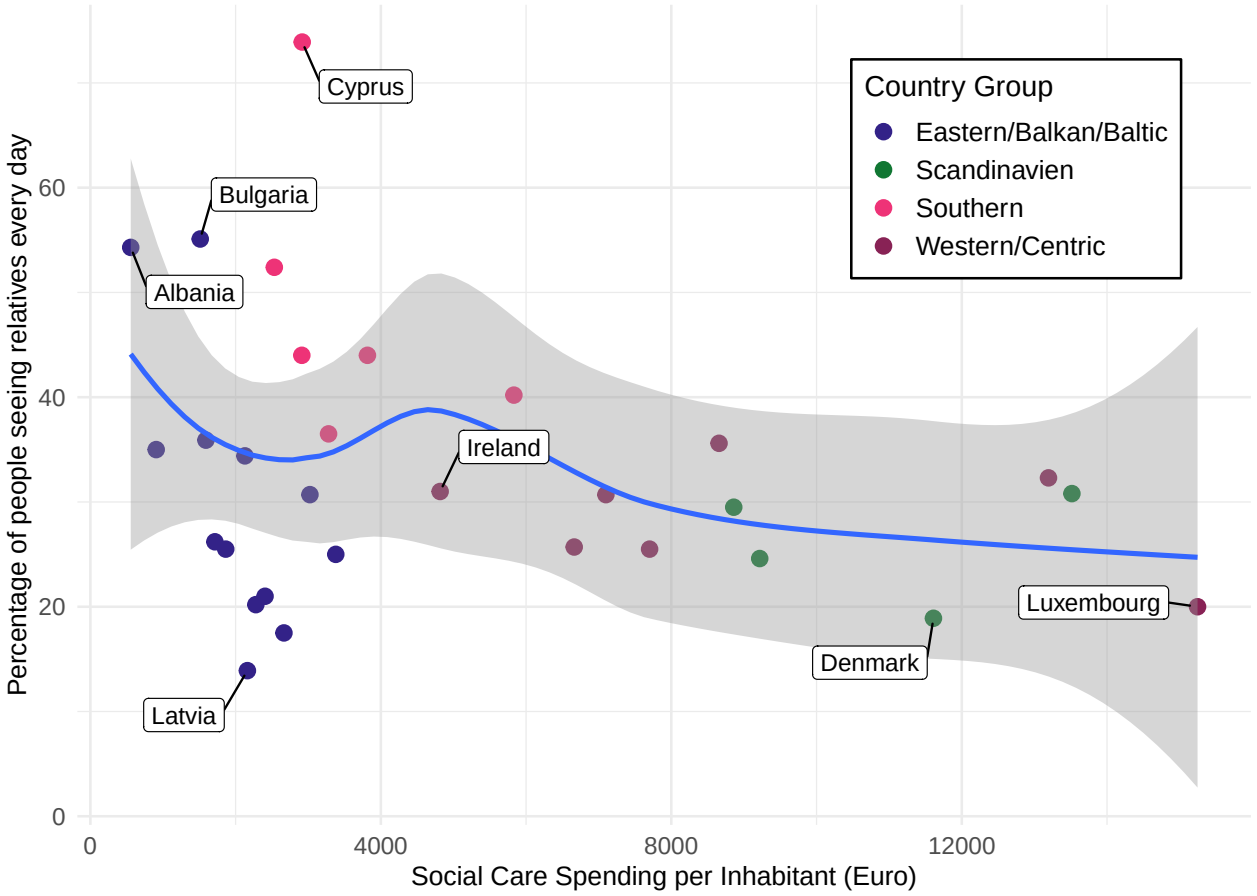


Finland consistently demonstrates high social spending, particularly in Old Age, and Sickness and Health Care, reflecting its public-centred regime. Romania shows the lowest spending across all categories, consistent with its family-centred model. Ireland's spending profile lies between these two extremes. While near the EU average in several categories, spending on areas such as Social Exclusion remains limited. Ireland allocates more to Family and Children than Romania, but overall spending on care-related areas (Old Age, Family/ Children and Disability) remains relatively low, reflecting its hybrid care regime. The EU average consistently falls between Finland and the two other countries, acting as a benchmark for regional trends. These differences highlight how care regime structures shape spending patterns, even within the integrated EU policy environment.

4 Social Care Expenditure and the Role of Family

Family remains an important component of Ireland's care regime, with family carers providing unpaid work that saves the state over €20 billion annually (Family Carers Ireland, 2022). While high levels of informal care are often associated with family-centred regimes, Ireland's case illustrates that hybrid regimes can also rely substantially on family support. To explore the relationship between family involvement and state spending, Eurostat (2025) data on the frequency of family contact across EU countries was used. The variable "*Every day*", representing the percentage of people who see relatives daily, is plotted against per-capita social spending for 2022. No direction of the causal relationship is assumed.

Figure 5: Social Care Spending vs Frequency of Family Contact (2022)



The smoothed regression line shows a downward trend, indicating a negative relationship between social care spending and the frequency of family contact across European countries. Ireland has roughly €5,000 per capita spending and 30% daily family contact. It falls below Southern European family-contact levels and below Scandinavian spending levels, reflecting a hybrid care regime. These results emphasise how variations in care regimes influence both state spending and family involvement.

5 Conclusion

This data report shows how social care spending across the EU varies significantly according to care regime type. Public-centred regimes, like Finland, invest heavily in social care, while family-centred regimes, such as Romania rely more on informal care. Ireland's hybrid model sits between these extremes, combining moderate state spending with substantial family support. The negative relationship between social care spending and frequency of family contact highlights how state provision and informal care complement each other. This analysis shows the continued influence of care regime structures on spending patterns. However, further research is needed to explore causality, within-country variations, and the limits of using expenditure data alone.

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7 Appendix

7.1 Codebooks

Table 1: Social Spending Data

Variable	Description	Type
unit	Measurement Unit (Euro per inhabitant)	Character
country	Name of country	Character
year	Year of observation	Integer
disability	Expenditure per inhabitant on disability	Numeric (EUR)
social_exclusion	Expenditure per inhabitant on social exclusion	Numeric (EUR)
family_children	Expenditure per inhabitant on family and children	Numeric (EUR)
housing	Expenditure per inhabitant on housing	Numeric (EUR)
old_age	Expenditure per inhabitant on old-age	Numeric (EUR)
sickness_health_care	Expenditure per inhabitant on sickness and healthcare	Numeric (EUR)
survivors	Expenditure per inhabitant on survivors	Numeric (EUR)
unemployment	Expenditure per inhabitant on unemployment	Numeric (EUR)
total	Total public expenditure per inhabitant	Numeric (EUR)

Table 2: Domestic Demand Data

Variable	Description	Type
country	Name of country	Character
year	Year of observation	Integer
domestic_demand	Measurement unit (Million Euro)	Numeric
unit	Total Domestic Demand	Character

Table 3: Family Data

Variable	Description	Type
person_category	Person category observed (family and relatives)	Character
unit	Measurement unit (percentage)	Character
country	Name of country	Character
year	Year of observation	Integer
every_day	Percentage seeing their relatives every day	Numeric